

Home Services

Pest Control · Septic & Sewer · Landscape · Pool · Appliance Repair · Moving

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

IN THIS ISSUE	PEST CONTROL New York's neonicotinoid prohibition expands December 31, 2026 to imidacloprid, thiamethoxam and acetamiprid on outdoor ornamental plants and turf.	SEPTIC & SEWER North Carolina has up to \$22.5 million for septic repair and replacement, and county programs in New York and Ohio are paying up to \$10,000 a household.	LANDSCAPE EPA opened a September 24 comment window on August 25 for studies missing from its glyphosate literature search, feeding a new human health risk assessment due late this year.	 Read it online This issue, and every one before it
	POOL SPS PoolCare launched a national group purchasing organization on August 25, open to independent pool service companies of any size, with no disclosed discount.	APPLIANCE REPAIR DOE's amended commercial water heating standards bind equipment manufactured on and after October 6, 2026, and the petition to delay them to 2030 has not been decided.	MOVING FMCSA sent its supplemental broker transparency rule to the White House on August 27, the last step before publication and a comment period.	
	BACKGROUND SIGNAL The invoice fraud that reads your email first			

MONEY · EVERY TRADE IN THIS ISSUE

Pending home sales fell 2.3% in July to 71.2, the lowest since January, and new single-family sales fell 10.5% to a 607,000 annual rate.

The National Association of Realtors released July pending home sales on August 18. The index fell 2.3% for the month to 71.2 and 2.2% over the year, its lowest reading since January 2026, with all four regions down month over month: West 52.7 (-4.7%), Northeast 64.5 (-2.0%), South 85.0 (-2.2%), Midwest 73.3 (-0.7%). "The highest mortgage rates of the year hit right in the middle of summer, and that's pulling back contract signings," said NAR chief economist Lawrence Yun. Pending sales are signed contracts, so they lead closings by roughly a month.

The Census Bureau and HUD released July new residential sales on August 25. New single-family homes sold at a seasonally adjusted annual rate of 607,000, down 10.5% from June's 678,000 and down 6.3% from 648,000 a year earlier. The median new-home price was \$393,800, off 0.9% year over year. Inventory stood at 488,000 homes, and months' supply rose from 8.5 in June to 9.6 in July - the highest of the past six months. Census cautions it takes four months to establish a trend, but the direction of both releases is the same.

Closings and new builds are the demand channel for install work: new drainfields and tanks, pool construction, landscape installs, appliance sets, termite letters at closing, and the move itself. Recurring service - route stops, maintenance plans, repairs - does not move with the housing cycle and is what carries a fall like this.

Moving companies are the most exposed of the six trades in this issue, because a pending-sales index is close to a forward order book.

The regional split matters more than the national number. The West is worst on both cuts: index 52.7 and down 7.1% over the year. The Midwest is the only region up year over year, at +1.7%. The South is still the largest market at 85.0 but down 3.0% over the year. On the new-build side, 488,000 unsold homes and 9.6 months of supply mean builders clear inventory before they start again, so install pipelines tied to new construction stay thin into the winter even if rates ease.

What to do about it: Re-forecast the fourth quarter with install revenue down and service revenue flat, not with one blended growth number. Pull your own last-90-days mix of install versus recurring work and set a target for moving points of it onto contract. Call your three largest referral sources - realtors, builders, property managers - and ask what they have under contract for October and November, then staff to that rather than to last year. If you sell install work, put a written expiration on every open quote so a job priced in June is not built in December at June's price. Movers should tighten deposit and cancellation terms now, before the slow quarter. Nothing here requires cutting price; it requires knowing which half of the book is exposed.

NAR - Pending Home Sales Report Shows 2.3% Decrease in July (released August 18, 2026) · Census Bureau and HUD - Monthly New Residential Sales, July 2026 (released August 25, 2026)

PEST CONTROL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

New York's neonicotinoid prohibition expands December 31, 2026 to imidacloprid, thiamethoxam and acetamiprid on outdoor ornamental plants and turf.

Why it matters: Three actives at the center of grub, ant and perimeter programs come off outdoor ornamental and turf use in New York on December 31, 2026 - four months out. Applicators who still use them for invasive-species or environmental-emergency treatment must complete an annual DEC-approved course. DEC took input on possible changes at an August 27 virtual stakeholder meeting on the Birds and Bees Protection Act rules, so

New York State DEC - Pesticides (neonicotinoid restrictions and Birds and Bees Protection Act rulemaking)

scope can move, but nothing is repealed and the date stands. A ban on treated corn, soybean and wheat seed follows January 1, 2029. This week: inventory every product on the truck by active ingredient, not brand name, and get a written answer from your distributor on what replaces imidacloprid for turf and ornamental work before you set spring pricing.

DEMAND

NPMA's August 26 fall and winter forecast calls for a warmer, wetter season that extends tick, mosquito, ant and cockroach activity across most of the country.

Why it matters: The forecast points to a longer billable season, not a shorter one. NPMA's entomologists expect prolonged warmth to keep ticks and ants active later in the Mid-Atlantic and New England and to delay the handoff to rodents and Asian lady beetles. The Southeast is warm and wet, extending mosquito and cockroach activity with rodents arriving as temperatures drop; the North Central and South Central get the same read for

ants and mosquitoes; the Intermountain and Southwest expect heavier rainfall driving scorpions and spiders indoors. It is a weather read, not booked revenue, and NPMA published no percentages. This week: hold mosquito and tick routes three to four weeks past your usual cutoff, and tell crew leads the rodent-exclusion push starts later than last year.

NPMA - Summer's Not Clocking Out Yet: Warmer Fall Forecast Could Extend Pest Activity Across the U.S. (August 26, 2026)

SEPTIC & SEWER

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

North Carolina has up to \$22.5 million for septic repair and replacement, and county programs in New York and Ohio are paying up to \$10,000 a household.

Why it matters: This is county money a contractor has to go get. North Carolina's State Water Infrastructure Authority has up to \$22.5 million, Helene damage first but other failing systems eligible, through four nonprofits including MountainTrue and the Water Well Trust. Pitt County adds a \$250,000 Clean Water State Revolving Fund decentralized-systems pilot loan. In New York, Jefferson County has \$550,000 and Seneca County \$300,000 under the State Septic System Replacement Fund, each paying up to 50% of a job to a \$10,000 cap. Columbiana County, Ohio has a \$200,000 Water Pollution Control Loan Fund grant paying 50%, 85% or 100% by income. Deadlines were not published. This week: call the administering agency in every county you serve and ask to be on its contractor list.

Pumper - Rules and Regs: Hurricane Helene Septic Repair Funds Available (August 19, 2026)

MONEY

A bipartisan bill introduced this month would exclude state and local septic repair grants from taxable income, which is unsettled today.

Why it matters: Reps. Greg Steube, Aaron Bean, Gus Bilirakis and Tom Suozzi introduced the SEPTIC Act - Septic Exclusion for Property Owners through Tax-free Infrastructure Compensation - to amend the tax code so state and local septic repair grants are not taxable income. Today it is unclear whether they are, and that is a live objection: a homeowner offered \$10,000 toward a \$25,000 replacement discounts it if they expect a tax bill behind it. Program sizes run from \$150 Missouri rebates to \$25,000 caps in North Carolina and New York. It has been introduced only - no bill number in the trade report, no effective date. This week: stop telling customers grants are tax-free, put the uncertainty in writing on the estimate, and send them to their own preparer.

Pumper - Lawmakers: SEPTIC Act Would Keep Septic Repair Grants Tax-Free (August 3, 2026)

LANDSCAPE

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA opened a September 24 comment window on August 25 for studies missing from its glyphosate literature search, feeding a new human health risk assessment due late this year.

Why it matters: EPA's August 25 notice, docket EPA-HQ-OPP-2009-0361, asks the public to identify peer-reviewed studies its open-literature search missed. Comments close September 24, 2026, and submissions need open access to the article and its data. The search feeds an updated glyphosate human health risk assessment EPA expects to finish in late 2026 - the first full re-look at the active behind most commercial non-selective weed control on hardscape, bed edges and renovation work. The notice changes no label and restricts no use; it fixes the calendar, because an assessment landing in late 2026 is what any 2027 label change would be built on. This week: ask your chemical supplier what their glyphosate contingency is for 2027, and price one non-glyphosate program.

Federal Register - Glyphosate Open Literature Search To Inform Human Health Risk Assessment; Notice of Availability (August 25, 2026)

LABOR

Fewer than 3,000 H-2B numbers remain in the 33,000 first-half FY2027 cap, with 30,125 already approved or pending as of late August.

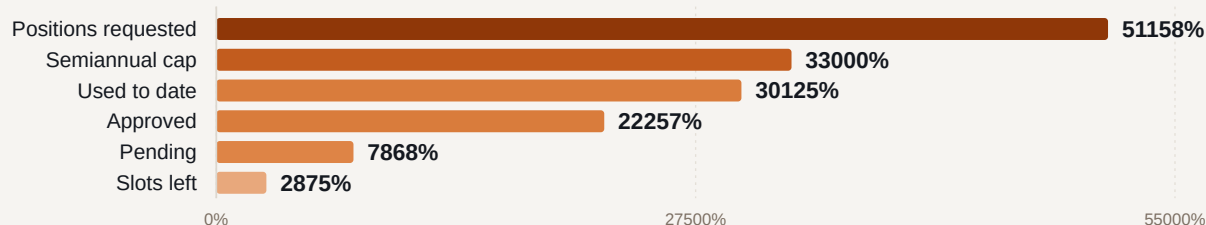
Why it matters: The cap covering October 1, 2026 through March 31, 2027 start dates is nearly gone. As of the late-August count, 30,125 of the 33,000 statutory numbers were spoken for - 22,257 approved and 7,868 pending - leaving fewer than 3,000, faster than the same point last year. July filings show why: DOL's Office of Foreign Labor Certification randomized 2,625 H-2B applications covering 51,158 worker positions for October 1 starts, and Group A alone, 1,881 cases, held enough to reach the cap. This advances last issue's FY2026 third supplemental allocation, whose window still closes September 15. This week: if you need winter or early-spring crew, call immigration counsel now and begin the spring 2027 process rather than waiting for the cap to close.

Kirchner Immigration - FY2027 H-2B Cap Count: Numbers Are Closing Faster Than Last Year (August 26, 2026) - U.S. Department of Labor, Office of Foreign Labor Certification - Announcements (H-2B randomization results, July 8, 2026)

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / H-2B, FIRST-HALF FY2027

Employers asked for 51,158 seasonal worker positions against a 33,000 cap that is now within 3,000 of full.

H-2B worker positions for first-half FY2027 start dates (Oct 1, 2026-Mar 31, 2027); DOL OFLC randomization July 8, 2026 and USCIS cap count as reported August 26, 2026



The distance between the first two bars is demand that does not get filled at any wage. Of the 33,000 statutory numbers, 30,125 are already approved or pending, leaving fewer than 3,000 for October-through-March starts. A landscape or moving company that needs winter crew is working with weeks of runway, not months, and the spring 2027 process has to start before this cap formally closes. Source: [Kirchner Immigration - FY2027 H-2B Cap Count \(August 26, 2026\)](#)

POOL

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

SPS PoolCare launched a national group purchasing organization on August 25, open to independent pool service companies of any size, with no disclosed discount.

Why it matters: BlueWave Advantage pools the buying volume of independent pool service companies on chemicals, equipment and parts, with Heritage Pool Supply Group handling fulfillment. Any independent operator is eligible, startups included. No discount percentage, member count or dollar saving was disclosed, so the benefit is a quote to obtain, not a budget line. Note the structure: the sponsor is a pool service company that also runs routes, so you would share purchase data with a competitor for the same accounts. Check exclusivity, minimum-volume and data terms before signing. This week: put your last twelve months of chemical and equipment spend on one sheet, then have BlueWave and your distributor quote the identical basket and compare landed cost, not list price.

AQUA Magazine - SPS PoolCare Launches BlueWave Advantage Buying Group to Reduce Costs for Member Companies (August 25, 2026)

DEMAND

A funded consolidator bought its way into the Washington, Maryland and Virginia pool service market this month, its twelfth acquisition in two years.

Why it matters: Azureon has acquired Pooltek Services of Rockville, Maryland (Pool & Spa News, August 17) - its twelfth acquisition since the platform was founded in 2024 - expanding into Washington, D.C., Maryland and Virginia; Pooltek's ownership keeps a significant stake. The same week Easton Select, also founded in 2024, reached fifteen brands by buying JPS Pool Service in Pomfret, Connecticut and J. Gallant in Newbury, Massachusetts, and Fluidra acquired the Datapool pool analytics platform. What you feel is not the deal but the aftermath: recruiters calling your technicians, and a buyer with cheaper capital bidding for your accounts at renewal. This week: confirm your service agreements auto-renew, put lead technicians on current pay, and get a valuation range on file.

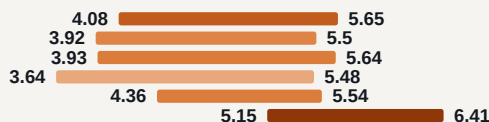
Pool & Spa News - digital edition, August 17, 2026

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / GASOLINE VS DIESEL

Diesel runs \$1.57 a gallon above regular gasoline nationally, and the premium is widest on the Gulf Coast.

Retail price, dollars per gallon: low = regular gasoline, high = on-highway diesel, week of August 24, 2026; EIA weekly survey released August 25, 2026

U.S. average
East Coast
Midwest
Gulf Coast
Rocky Mountain
West Coast



Every region pays a diesel premium, but not the same one: \$1.84 on the Gulf Coast and \$1.70 in the Midwest against \$1.18 in the Rocky Mountain region and \$1.26 on the West Coast. Diesel itself moved 39.5 cents in two weeks, from \$5.257 on August 10 to \$5.652 on August 24. Where the premium is widest, a gasoline van earns its keep over a diesel truck faster. Source: [EIA - Gasoline and Diesel Fuel Update, week of August 24, 2026](#)

APPLIANCE REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

DOE's amended commercial water heating standards bind equipment manufactured on and after October 6, 2026, and the petition to delay them to 2030 has not been decided.

Why it matters: The standards bind commercial water heating equipment manufactured on and after October 6, 2026 - five weeks out. Covered classes: gas-fired storage and instantaneous water heaters, hot water supply boilers, electric storage and instantaneous units, and residential-duty gas-fired storage models. DOE projected life-cycle savings of \$119 to \$1,570 per unit and simple payback of 5.8 to 9.4 years. Gas industry associations petitioned DOE on April 27, 2026 (docket EERE-2026-BT-STD-0001) to move compliance to January 1, 2030 at the earliest; DOE took comment for 30 days and has published no final action, so October 6 stands. This week: ask your wholesaler which model numbers stop being built after October 6 and what the compliant replacement costs, then reprice open quotes.

Federal Register - Energy Conservation Program: Energy Conservation Standards for Commercial Water Heating Equipment (compliance required on and after October 6, 2026) - Federal Register (public inspection) - DOE, Notification of Petition for Rulemaking, docket EERE-2026-BT-STD-0001 (April 27, 2026)

SUPPLY

Commerce closed comment August 27 on adding heat exchange unit parts and welding machine parts to the Section 232 tariff list at a proposed 25%.

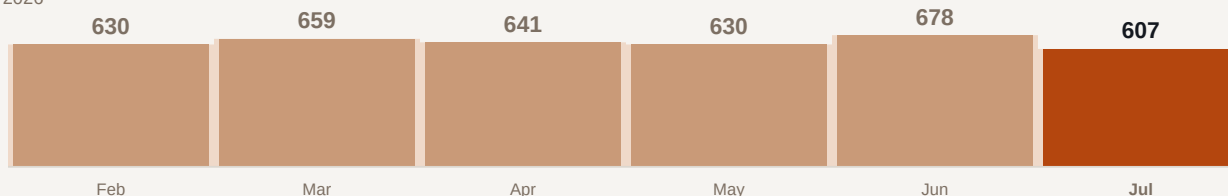
Why it matters: The Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) would add fourteen derivative articles to the Section 232 steel, aluminum and copper list; two land on a repair shop: heat exchange unit parts, HTSUS 8419.90.3000, at a proposed 25%, and welding machine parts, 8515.90.2000, at 25%. Electric conductor cables, hydraulic engine and motor parts, and fire extinguishers are on the same list at 25%. Comments closed August 27 under docket BIS-2026-0331. BIS says the Administrative Procedure Act does not formally apply to a national security action, so a determination can follow without warning. The rates are proposed, not in effect. This week: get written confirmation from your parts distributor that quotes for coils, heat exchangers and evaporator assemblies are tariff-locked.

Federal Register - Request for Public Comments on the Proposed Implementation of Duties on Additional Aluminum, Steel, and Copper Derivative Articles Under Section 232 (comments closed August 27, 2026)

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / NEW-HOME PIPELINE

New single-family home sales fell 10.5% in July to a 607,000 annual rate, the weakest of the past six months.

New single-family houses sold, seasonally adjusted annual rate, thousands of units; Census Bureau and HUD, released August 25, 2026



June's 678,000 looked like a turn, and July gave it back and more. Months' supply went from 8.5 to 9.6 with 488,000 new homes unsold, and that inventory clears before builders start again. Install work tied to new construction - pool builds, new drainfields, landscape installs, appliance sets - is the line that thins first. Recurring service revenue is what carries a quarter like this. Source: [Census Bureau and HUD - Monthly New Residential Sales, July 2026](#)

REGULATION

FMCSA sent its supplemental broker transparency rule to the White House on August 27, the last step before publication and a comment period.

Why it matters: The supplemental proposal went to the Office of Management and Budget on August 27, the last stop before Federal Register publication and a comment period. Executive order caps OMB review at 90 days, extendable by 30, so publication by year end is plausible. The 2020 petitions behind it asked FMCSA to make brokers provide electronic transaction records within 48 hours of a request, and to bar clauses waiving that

right. FMCSA published its first proposal in November 2024. No effective or compliance date exists yet, and the text stays private until it clears OMB. For a mover running brokered freight between household-goods jobs, it decides whether you see what the shipper paid. This week: pull your broker agreements and flag every waiver-of-records clause.

Overdrive - FMCSA moves on broker transparency (August 28, 2026)

MOVING

CONTINUED

MONEY

UCR pre-registration for 2027 opens October 1, and FMCSA's proposed fees would raise a small fleet's bill about 20% for the first time in three years.

Why it matters: Unified Carrier Registration is owed by every interstate for-hire carrier, household goods movers included, in its base state, and 2027 pre-registration opens October 1, 2026 with fees due before January 1, 2027. FMCSA proposed an average 20% increase on April 7, 2026: bracket B1, zero to two trucks, from \$46 to \$55; B2, three to five, \$138 to \$167; B3, six to twenty, \$276 to \$333; B4, twenty-one to one hundred, \$963

to \$1,163. Comments closed May 7, 2026. The 2025 and 2026 fees were identical, so this breaks a two-year flat run. No final rule was published as of August 30, so the 2027 number is proposed, not settled. This week: budget the higher figure, put October 1 on the calendar, and confirm which bracket your truck count puts you in before you file.

Federal Register - Fees for the Unified Carrier Registration Plan and Agreement (proposed 2027 fees, April 7, 2026) · Unified Carrier Registration Plan - Fee Brackets (approved 2025 and 2026 fees)

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of \$3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to \$2.77 billion in 2024 from \$2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and \$20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A business that emails estimates, work orders and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a home services operator. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from \$2,946,830,270, \$2,770,151,146 and \$3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.

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2SEE EVERYTHING — YOUR DASHBOARDS

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CERNODESK · OWNER DASHBOARD

example view · this month

ANSWERED312BOOKED88CAPTURED124MISSED0

47 calls caught after hours — a 9-to-5 desk would have missed them

CERNO DEAL DESK · OWNER DASHBOARD

example view · this month

OPEN12AWAITING4SENT18WON71

6 min average from request to quote sent · 71% estimate → won

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